Entrepreneurial Journey:
Co-founder & Operations Manager
at Cliché Café & Lounge

Overview:
My entrepreneurial journey began in early 2019 when I acquired a traditional family coffee business located in a prime District 1 alley in Ho Chi Minh City. I completely restructured and rebranded the business, transforming it into a vintage 1980s Saigon-themed café. Beyond being a personal milestone, this venture served as a rigorous, real-world business environment where I directly built, operated, and steered a company through unprecedented market turbulence.









End-to-End Business Operations & Community Building

Operations Strategy: As Co-founder, I was responsible for optimizing resources and diversifying revenue streams to maximize profitability within a fixed physical space.

- **Service Diversification:** Innovated the operational model by running a traditional coffee shop during weekdays and transitioning into a vibrant Acoustic Lounge on weekends.
- **Customer Base Expansion:** Capitalized on the central location by introducing a targeted lunch menu to capture the local office worker demographic.
- **Community Engagement:** Fostered brand loyalty and created added value for customers by hosting free, recurring book exchange workshops.









Navigating Unprecedented Challenges (Covid-19 Era)

Crisis Response: The business's survival and adaptability were put to the ultimate test when the Covid-19 pandemic began in February 2020.

- **Agile Adaptation:** Successfully guided Cliché through the first three waves of the pandemic by remaining flexible and pivoting operations quickly.
- **Sales Channel Optimization:** Rapidly integrated and partnered with online food delivery applications to maintain cash flow during restricted periods.
- **Practical Marketing:** Continuously tested and deployed creative promotional campaigns to stimulate demand and retain our customer base during lockdowns.






The Foundation for Future Leadership

The Outcome: In May 2021, during the most severe Covid-19 wave that mandated the closure of all non-essential businesses, I made the strategic decision to divest and transfer ownership due to personal financial limitations. Knowing when to decisively exit proved to be a critical lesson in risk management.

Acquired Skillsets: Managing Cliché for over two years acted as a practical MBA, building a strong foundation for my core professional competencies:

- **Leadership & Team Management:** Building trust and maintaining team morale through highly volatile and uncertain periods.
- **High-Pressure Handling:** Remaining analytical and making decisive choices during prolonged business crises.
- **Resource Management & P&L:** Optimizing cash flow, managing tight budgets, and allocating limited resources efficiently.
- **Cross-functional Communication:** Collaborating and negotiating effectively with customers, vendors, and stakeholders.







